Prakash Sir overheard this conversation. He took a quick decision. “The girls’ relay team, gather here in five minutes,” he called out. All the girls came together. “Girls, I have been watching you all. You need some more practice, more time on the field. You are not doing enough,” he told them. VOCIFEROUS protests greeted this. “All right, all right, girls, calm down,” he held up his hands, placating them. “Tell me, what is your goal. To WIN the race, isn’t it? Not just to make an attempt. To win! Are we agreed?”

The girls murmured their assent.

“I know you have been training. You just need to give a little extra push to your efforts to win. I know all of you have it in you,” he told them.

“Right, let us start with these exercises.” He showed them exercises that would allow their legs to stretch more, stride faster. Then he trained them in the skill of passing the baton without losing speed. “Don’t slow down when you near your next team member,”

Prakash Sir said,“Maintain your SPEED while passing your BATON. Only when the baton has left your hand, you slow down. Do you understand? And you, who are going to receive the baton, also keep in motion, jogging. All right enough for today. Report to me same time tomorrow again.” Then turning to Rucha, he said, “I want a word with you. You are apt to slow down after starting well,” said Prakash Sir. “Don’t do that. Maintain your speed,” he advised her.

“Sir, I am not very good,” Rucha said dolefully.



“No self-doubts, Rucha! This is exactly what I have been wanting to tell you. You must have a POSITIVE ATTITUDE. Don’t even think of losing. See yourself winning! Think to win! Only to win! You can do it, I can feel it.” Rucha went home with Prakash Sir’s words ringing in her ears.

The next few days he saw the girls training extra hard. Prakash Sir was never far, even as he trained other children.

The day of the sports meet DAWNED and the children piled into buses to reach the venue. There was laughter and a great deal of joviality as Prakash Sir had seen

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